9 Parts of Desire

By Heather Raffo

INTRODUCTION

On February 13, 1991, the US military fired laser-guided "smart" bombs into a large civilian shelter in al-Amiriyya, a residential neighborhood in Baghdad. The bombing killed 408 civilians. The invasion of Iraq and the liberation of Kuwait had begun. But it would be 12 years before Saddam Hussein is removed from power and executed for crimes against humanity.

Heather Raffo in her play 9 Parts of Desire gives voice to the diverse population of Iraqi women, struggling to survive . . . struggling to be heard.

UMM GHADA: **(Pg 28)** I named my daughter Ghada.

Ghada means tomorrow.

So I am Umm Ghada, Mother of Ghada.

I live in yellow trailer

outside Amiriyya bomb shelter

I was inside

with nine from my family

talking, laughing

then such a pounding, shaking

everything is fire

I couldn't find my children

I couldn't find my way out

In the whole day later

I am searching, searching charred bodies

bodies they were fused together

the only body I did recognize

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is my daughter Ghada

so I did take her name *[with so much pride]*

I am Umm Ghada, Mother of Ghada.

TRANSITION

Iraq is a world that exists far beyond what we see on our television screens. And since the early 1990's the women of Iraq have borne often silent witness to all that has unfolded in the Middle East. Today their silence is broken by the voices of Umm Ghada, the caretaker of the Amiriyya shelter, now a museum to honor the dead; a doctor who has returned to her homeland to serve her people; and Huda, an elderly political rebel who fled Iraq during the time of Saddam Hussein.

It is said that history is written by the victor. But perhaps, just perhaps, history is a compilation of many realities.

THE DOCTOR: **(Pg 20-21)** *[nauseated, she throws up; washes her hands, then dries them. She is exhausted]* I'm sorry, it's probably just the smell of the sewage backing up in the ward. I feel fine, fine, let's go on, it's just . . . Damn it! I lost her, the baby should be dead, not her. God she had enough, she had three girls at home, but she insisted, hoping for a boy. What am I supposed to tell her husband? Here, it's your first-born son, sorry he has two heads?

More than ultrasound, incubators, Panadol, anything, I need some -- who can I ask? Just this month, I've started counting: six babies no head, four abnormally large heads, now today another one with two heads. Such high levels of genetic damage does not occur naturally. These things . . . you see them in textbooks.

HUDA: **(Pg 19-20)** Some in the opposition praise America one hundred percent

Personally, I have my doubts about American policy,

still I prefer chaos to permanent repression and cruelty

Saddam was the worst enemy to the people

He beheaded seventy women for being prostitutes,

but he made them prostitutes.

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Saddam's stooges, they'd kidnap a woman
just going from her car to her house,
and take her as a slave, sex lave
or house slave when they were in their hideouts,
and when they'd finish with her
he would go to her family saying "She is a prostitute"
and he'd behead her and put her head in the street.
There was no law if you are a prostitute -- you are beheaded.
So, what chaos is worse then this?
Let it be chaos at least something will come out of it.

UMM GHADA: (Pg 29-31) *[enters the shelter; it is the first time we see her subtle limp]*

This is Amiriyya bomb shelter.
Here, on the ceiling, you can see
charred handprints and footprints
from people who lay in the top bunks.
And here a silhouette of a woman
vaporized from heat.
This huge room became an oven,
and they pressed to the walls to escape from the flames.
In the basement too
bombs burst the pipes
hot water came up to five feet
and boiled the people.
the walls are stuck with hairs and skin.

The U.S. said they thought this is
communication center for military.
Myself,
I think they were testing bomb --

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these bombs had never been used before, but it is special
two-bomb design for breaking only a bomb shelter.

HUDA: **(Pg 39-41)** Let the young ones living there have a chance with the policies
but they are too afraid to speak up
they are shell-shocked, all these girls
they go backward
they abandon their education and now,
now they are wearing the veils.
Their grandmothers are more liberated than them.

I wanted, we all wanted Saddam to go during the Gulf War.
that was our moment – the people made this big rebellion --
sixteen of the eighteen provinces fell
and they were sure America would help them

But America turned its back. America made a no-fly zone
but when they saw Saddam going with his helicopters
to execute his own people
they allowed him to fly. It was a bloodbath,

Saddam killed tens of thousands, trucks full,
and buried them just mass graves.
Then the worst thirteen years' suffering --
This what do you call it? Hisar? Embargo?

And it made Saddam stronger
and the country more backward and religious.

THE DOCTOR: **(Pg 21-22)** And the cancers, I've never seen them before in Iraq, girls of seven, eight years old with breast cancer. I told this girl, ten years old, she came in, she thought her breasts were developing but it was only on one side. It was the

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cancer. But it's toddlers even with breast cancer, more than one cancer in the same patient, whole families all suffering from cancer –

And what can stop it? I mean the children, they play at the sites even when they're fenced off, they take the bullets to school to show their classmates what they collected from America. One came in wearing a bullet around his neck-a bullet tipped in depleted uranium around his neck.

It's in all the water, it's in the food, but if it's airborne like they say -- It could be depleted uranium, or chemicals that were released from the bombings during the Gulf War. They say the radiation is at eighty-four times the safety limit. But who can clean it? Ever? We will have this depleted uranium for what-four thousand years? How many generations is that growing up handicapped?

It's better, maybe, death -- I don't care, honestly I don't care what I say. I'm a little ashamed of myself but it sickens me. We won't survive it, I won't, I'm a doctor, if I can't do anything. We all trained in the West, I could have been anywhere, I came back. We had the best hospitals in the Middle East, everyone was coming to us, and what are we now? We're the experiment.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Heather Raffo
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AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CA State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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Recommended sites for background research:

- **The Amiriyya shelter bombing, Baghdad, Feb. 13, 1991**
  https://www.nytimes.com/2016/02/17/world/middleeast/25th-anniversary-of-us-involvement-passes-quietly-for-iraqis-unsure-of-future.html

- **Depleted Uranium and Radioactive Contamination in Iraq**
  https://www.globalresearch.ca/depleted-uranium-and-radioactive-contamination-in-iraq-an-overview/5605215

- **The Rise of ISIS in Iraq**
  https://www.rt.com/usa/372215-saddam-hussein-executed-iraq/

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